The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AP

Pete Hegseth claimed that **America** and **Israel** would soon gain control of Iranian airspace and deliver “death and destruction all day long”. The American defence secretary said the war was entering a new phase with “larger waves” of attacks. Mr Hegseth also said that a US Navy submarine sank an Iranian warship in the Indian Ocean. He called it America’s first sinking of an enemy ship with a torpedo since the second world war.

America’s **Senate** rejected a measure that would require Congress to approve Donald Trump’s military operations in Iran. The outcome was expected; the House of Representatives will vote on Thursday. Meanwhile Iran’s foreign ministry dismissed the White House’s claim that America’s pre-emptive attack was necessary because Mr Trump had a “feeling” that Iran would strike first. Mr Trump was acting “on behalf of Israel”, the ministry said.

Iranian **Kurdish** groups based in **Iraq** were reportedly considering entering the fray. The groups have been engaged in a decades-long conflict with Iran’s regime in an attempt to win greater autonomy. The Kurdistan Freedom Party confirmed talks with America and said some of its troops were on standby. Should they be deployed, they would be the first ground forces to enter the war.

China set an uninspiring growth target for 2026 of 4.5-5% at the National People's Congress, its rubber-stamp parliament. That is its lowest target since 1991. Last year it aimed for 5% growth (which, to little surprise, it hit exactly). The modest target comes despite persistent deflation and high youth unemployment, both proof that China should aim higher.

Voting began in **Nepal's** first general election since a student-led revolution in September forced KP Sharma Oli to resign as prime minister. The uprising was caused by widespread dissatisfaction with Nepal's three dominant parties. A newly established fourth party led by Balendra Shah, the rapper-turned-mayor of Kathmandu, is expected to sweep to victory.

Vladimir Putin suggested that **Russia** might stop supplying **Europe** with natural gas in favour of "other markets" that are willing to pay more for it. The EU slashed imports of Russian gas in December, committing to end them by 2027. Russia's president said his government would deliberate on the issue, but that the country would continue supplying gas to Serbia, Hungary and Slovakia.

British police arrested three men on suspicion of spying for **China**. One suspect is the spouse of Joani Reid, a Labour MP; she denied knowledge of her husband's activities. Last year Britain's top prosecutor dropped a case against two other men accused of funnelling "politically sensitive information" to the country. Critics have accused Sir Keir Starmer, Britain's prime minister, of being too soft on China.

Figure of the day: 18m, the number of people who migrated to America from southern and eastern Europe between 1890 and 1919. Read our history of immigration to America.

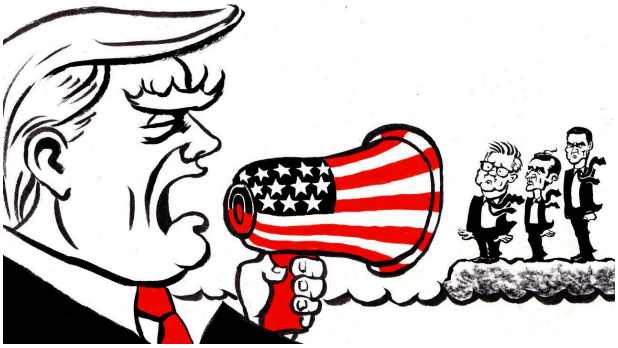


Illustration: David Simonds

What Iran means for transatlantic relations

Donald Trump has never bothered to hide his disdain for what he regards as his woke, feckless, peacenik European allies. And as if to confirm his worst fears, France's president has publicly condemned the American and Israeli attacks on Iran, for breaching international law; Spain's prime minister, Pedro Sánchez, called them "a disaster". He refused to allow American planes to take off from jointly operated bases, as did Britain's Sir Keir Starmer at first. America's president threatened to sever trade with Spain and trashed Sir Keir as "no Winston Churchill". Ouch.

Britain eventually gave America permission to use its bases, if only for defensive operations, and is sending a warship to Cyprus, where it has a base. Britain, after all, has the most to lose from a rupture in the so-called special relationship. France is also sending an aircraft-carrier to the Mediterranean. European countries were already preparing for a future less reliant on America. This nasty spat will only hasten it.

Photograph: Reuters

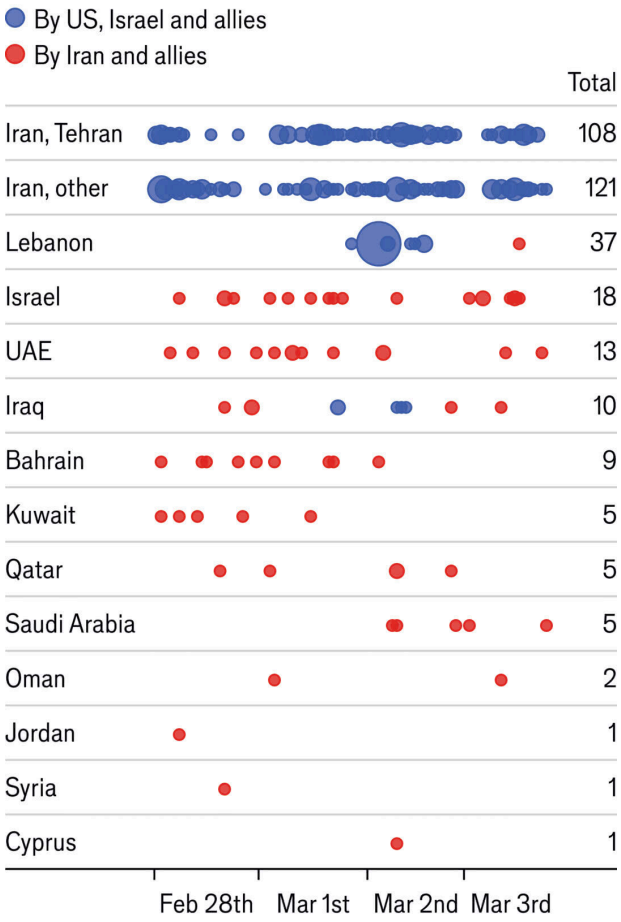
The war’s next phase

As America and Israel prepared to attack Iran, military planners drew up three lists of targets. The shortest was of sites to be attacked in the first wave of strikes on February 28th, including the office of the supreme leader, Ali Khamenei. The next was of high-priority targets for the first 100 hours of the war. The generals were uncertain whether Donald Trump would want to keep fighting beyond that point.

Now they are on a much longer list of lower-priority targets. These include thousands of military bases, factories and sites linked to the *basij*, the regime’s militia. The aim is either to grind the regime into submission or bring millions onto the streets to topple it. But the global economy is taking a major hit as energy prices rise. And America’s regional allies are running short of missile interceptors to fend off Iranian strikes. The question is whether Mr Trump will double down, or call time.

Epic fury

Location of reported strikes



Sources: Institute for the Study of War; AEI's Critical Threats Project

Photograph: AFP

A troubling leak at Anthropic

Anthropic is scrambling to rescue its already rocky relationship with the Trump administration, after a memo from the AI lab's head, Dario Amodei, was leaked. Anthropic fell out with the Department of War over demands that it agree to "all legal uses" of its AI systems. Mr Amodei blanched at the firm's systems potentially being used to make autonomous weapons or for mass domestic surveillance.

In the note, Mr Amodei blamed the spat on his failure to lavish "dictator-style praise" on the president. But he reserved his strongest criticisms for his former boss Sam Altman. Mr Altman's firm, OpenAI, struck a deal with the Pentagon shortly after the government threatened to classify Anthropic a "supply chain risk"—a troubling commercial restriction.

OpenAI admitted its deal looked opportunistic, but insisted it had set its own guardrails for the use of its AI. Mr. Amodei called that claim "mendacious", saying the technical safeguards OpenAI proposed to protect against mass surveillance were "safety theatre" and that the company's employees were "a gullible bunch". His outburst is unlikely to help Anthropic's reported bid to renegotiate with the Pentagon.

Photograph: Wojtek Jargilo/Avalon

Ukrainians lose their special status in Poland

For the past four years, Ukrainian refugees in Poland have been covered by an emergency law that offered them public health care and made it easier to start a business. No longer. A new law, which comes into force on Thursday, places the roughly 1.6m Ukrainians in Poland under general immigration and temporary-protection rules. Most Ukrainians will no longer be eligible for free health care, unless they pay into the public system or buy insurance. Those covered by Poland's temporary-protection scheme will have until March 2027 to apply for a residence permit.

The government wants to treat Ukrainians less as refugees and more as residents who form an indispensable part of the workforce. (The employment rate among Ukrainians is higher than the national average.) It also hopes the changes will stem rising public hostility towards Ukrainians. Polling suggests the share of Poles who support taking in refugees from their embattled neighbour has fallen dramatically, from 94% at the start of the war to 46% today.

Photograph: May James/ZUMA Press Wire/Shutterstock

China’s JD.com goes global

British shoppers will soon be able to have groceries delivered by Joybuy, a subsidiary of JD.com, a Chinese e-commerce group. China’s bustling online-retail industry is becoming more successful globally. Americans love shopping on Shein, a fast-fashion outlet (even if some European governments are wary of the company). And TikTok Shop is still run by China’s ByteDance despite a recent deal for the video-sharing app’s main algorithm in America to be controlled domestically. In South America, meanwhile, firms such as Meituan and DiDi are battling for the delivery market.

Does JD have what it takes to compete? Investors will learn more on Thursday when the company reports its earnings. Still, their main focus may be on China. JD has been embroiled in a delivery war with its domestic rivals since early 2025. Moreover, the group has not fully jumped on the AI bandwagon. That may dampen investors’ excitement, whatever flashy plans the group has for global expansion.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: What type of footwear, which raised the user's height, was very popular in the 1970s?

Wednesday: Arturo Toscanini, Leopold Stokowski and Claudio Abbado all achieved fame in what role?

Common sense is the instinct for truth.

Max Jacob